Part Four:
The Stages of Change

Session Four: **The Stages of Change**

Introduction

This session introduces young people to the Model of Stages of Change described in the introduction to this pack.

Aims

1. To identify that there are different stages to changing behaviour

2. To establish that people can be at different stages of changing their behaviour and to identify some of the things they might say at each stage

3. To try and associate colours, shapes and emotions with the stages of change

Activity 4a: **The Stages of Change**

This activity introduces the Model of Stages of Change to the young person.

You will need

☑ Activity Sheet 4a (i) – Stages of change
☑ Activity Sheet 4a (ii) – The Wheel of Change

What to do

- Either read through Activity Sheet 4a (i) with the young person or allow them to read through it themselves, as appropriate. Provide them with Activity Sheet 4a (ii) at the same time and point out the stages of change to the young person. The questions to encourage discussion are optional. Feel free to discuss as many or as few as seem appropriate

- Go back to "Ashley's problem". For each of the statements, try and work out where Ashley is on the wheel of change. You can either:
    1. Provide another copy of the worksheet, cut out the statements and let the young person place them on the wheel or
    2. Discuss the statements and let the young person write the stages of change on Activity Sheet 3c (ii) (where they stuck the "Ashley's problem" comments in order)

- There are no exact right or wrong answers. Answers may vary where young people offer different perspectives, but the statements generally reflect the following stages

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Table 3 – Ashley's problem and the Stages of Change

Statement	Stage of Change
Ashley enjoys smoking and doesn't realise it has become a habit	Prethinking (1)
Ashley saw an advert about how smoking can affect your health that worried her a bit	Thinking (2)
Ashley told her friends today that he was never going to smoke again	Deciding (3)
Ashley has just bought some nicotine gum to help her stop smoking	Doing (4)
Ashley has managed not to smoke for a while now and feels more healthy	Maintaining (5)
Ashley had stopped smoking three weeks ago, but she started again during her exams	Relapsing (6)

Activity 4b: **Sixty second challenge**

This task is designed to familiarise the young person with the Model of Stages of Change.

You will need

☑ Activity Sheet 4b *Sixty second challenge*
☑ Activity sheet 4c (i) *Shapes, Colours and emotions*
☑ Scissors
☑ Glue

What to do

- Cut out the shapes on Activity Sheet 4b (one set of shapes per young person).

- Give the young person 60 seconds to match the six shapes to the six stages of change. This should be done without too much thought and reflect the spontaneous feelings the young person has

- The young person should know that there is no right answer, only their answer

- Ask the young person to draw/stick the shapes onto Activity Sheet 4c (i)

- When the young person has finished they should move straight onto the next exercise, Shapes, Colours and Emotions

Activity 4c – **Shapes, Colours and Emotions**

The aim of this task is to enable the young person to develop a greater understanding of the emotions associated with the process of change.

You will need

☑ Activity sheet 4c (i) *Shapes, Colours and emotions*
☑ Activity sheet 4c (ii) *Feelings and emotions*
☑ Scissors
☑ Glue
☑ Coloured pencils/pens

What to do

- Ask the young person to think of a colour for each stage of change of the Wheel of Change. Colour in the boxes on Activity Sheet 4c (i).

- Look at Activity Sheet 4c (ii). Ask the young person to think of an emotion to go with each stage of the Wheel of Change. You may need to spend some time discussing the different emotions and what they mean. The list is not exhaustive and the young person may have ideas of their own.

Plenary

Using the completed Activity Sheet 4c (i) as a prompt, ask the young person to talk about some of their choices. Are they happy about the different stages of the wheel? Has colour coding helped? Why have they chosen those particular emotions?

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Activity Sheet 4a (i): **Stages of Change**

Remember in the last session we mentioned very briefly that there were six stages of changing behaviour. Have a look now at the activity sheet 4a (i) *The Wheel of Change*.

Stage 1 - **Prethinking**

At this stage, we may not think that our behaviour is causing a problem. For example, we may be staying out late with friends and having fun and not be aware that our family is worrying or our teachers have noticed that we are tired. At the prethinking stage, we do not think of our behaviour as a problem.

Things we might say at this stage

"It's the teachers – they won't get off my back."

"My parents are always nagging me about nothing."

"You're the one with the problem. Not me!"

Activity Sheet 4a (i): **Stages of Change**

Stage 2 – **Thinking**

At this stage, we realise that our behaviour might be a problem but we still keep doing it.

For example, we might have an idea that when we stay out late we make people in our family angry or our schoolwork gets affected, but we might be having a really good time. It may be hard for us to stop going out, even if we want to get on better at home and at school.

Things we might say at this stage

"I had a fantastic night last night, but I'm knackered now."

"I was tired and I wasn't listening; but the teacher always picks on me - it's so unfair."

"Oops, I've forgotten to do my science homework."

Activity Sheet 4a (i): **Stages of Change**

Stage 3 – **Deciding**

This is the point where we weigh up all the good things and the less good things about the behaviour and decide what we want to do. If we do make a decision to change, we move on to the next stage "Action". If we decide not to change, we can go back to the prethinking or thinking stages again.

Things we might say at this stage

"I'm finding it hard to concentrate in maths because I'm so tired after my late nights."

"If I keep going out I'm going to be dropped down a group."

"I don't think I can be bothered with my exams anymore." (You would go back to the prethinking stage)

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Activity Sheet 4a (i): **Stages of Change**

Stage 4 – **Doing**

This is where we actually take steps to do something different. For example, we might decide to tell our friends we are only going out on Fridays and decide to concentrate on school so we can get back on track with our exam work.

Things we might say at this stage

"I've got to stay in on Thursdays because I have tons of homework that night."

"I'm going to stop going out as much 'til I've done my exams because I want to go to College."

"I'll go out with another mate 'cos they're always back by nine."

Activity Sheet 4a (i): **Stages of Change**

Stage 5 – **Maintaining**

This is the stage where we keep the change going. Some people find this easier once they have made a decision. Others need some help and find keeping a diary or behaviour contract useful. Friends, teachers and family members can help us maintain change if we let them know what we are doing.

Things we might say at this stage

"I need to write down all the times in the week when I'm busy with school work, then I can see when I can go out with my friends."

"I've told my friend I've stopped going out on Wednesday so s/he gives me a ring to check I'm keeping it up."

"I'm keeping a diary of all the good and bad bits about staying in and working a bit harder."

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Activity Sheet 4a (i): **Stages of Change**

Stage 6 – **Relapsing**

Have you ever heard the saying "Two steps forward and one back"? Change is a bit like this. Even though we may have made a decision to change we won't always get it right. Relapsing means going back to our old ways. For example, someone who has given up smoking for three weeks might feel stressed and have a cigarette. They may feel as if they have failed, even though they had done well for three weeks.

When things go wrong, people can think that we haven't made any effort. This can be very frustrating and it is easy to slip back into old ways. We must focus on the times when we get it right, as well as the times when we don't.

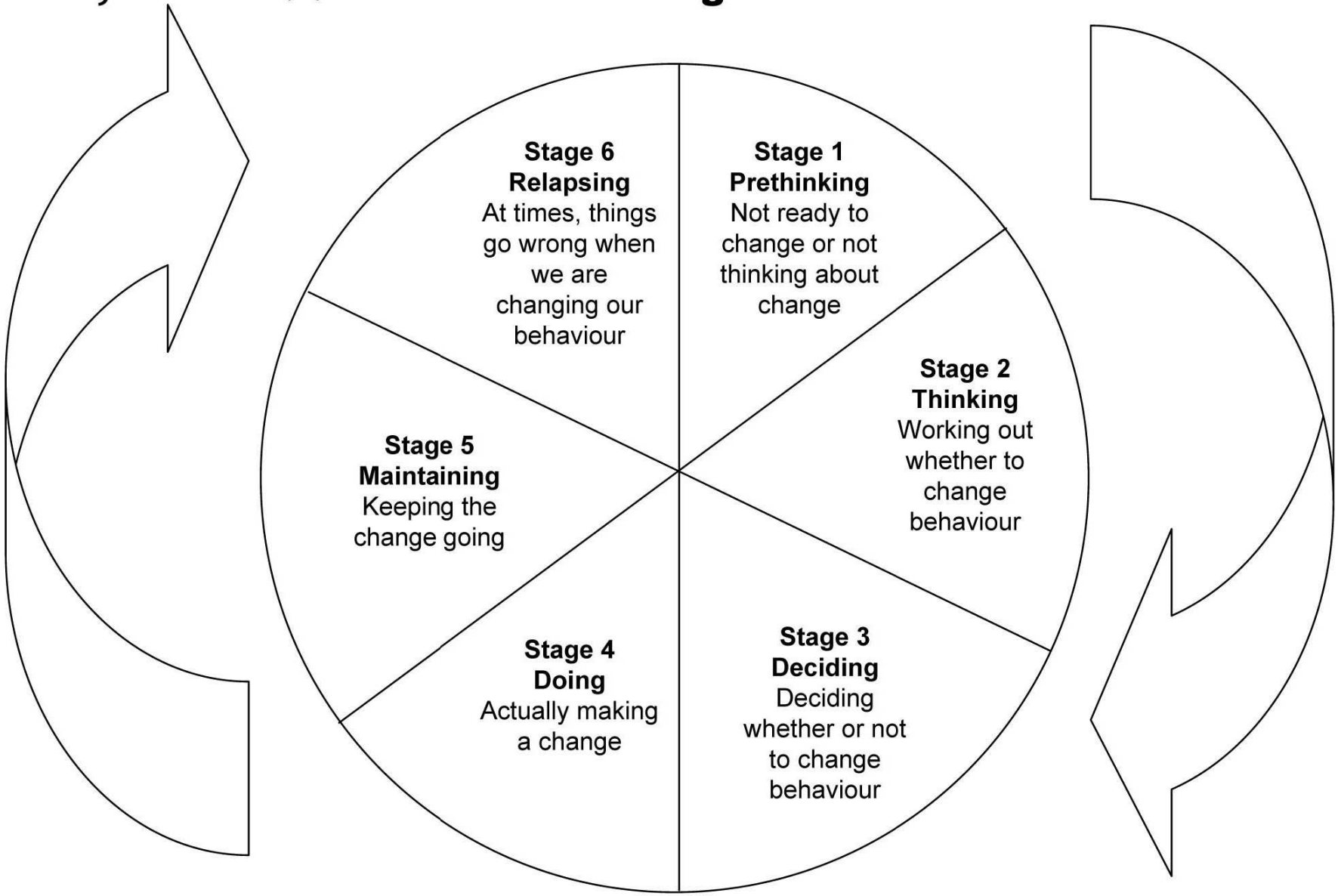
Things we might say at this stage

"I can't believe they persuaded me to stay out that long."

"I've blown it! I was trying so hard and now my dad's going to kill me."

"I just can't keep it up. I don't know why I'm even bothering."

Activity Sheet 4a (ii): **The Wheel of Change**



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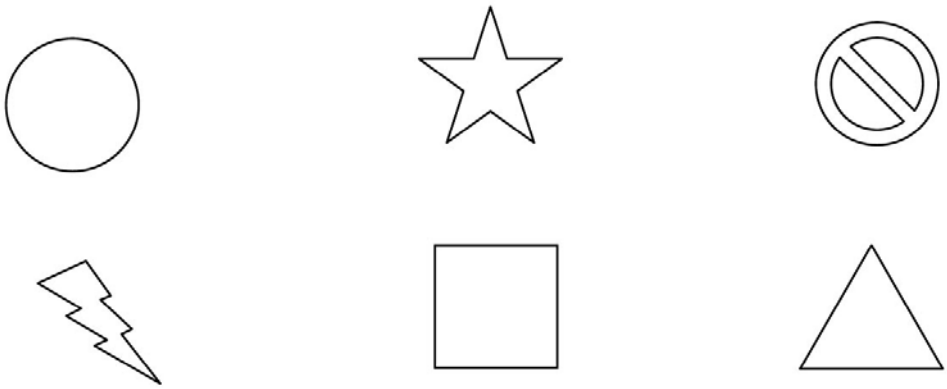
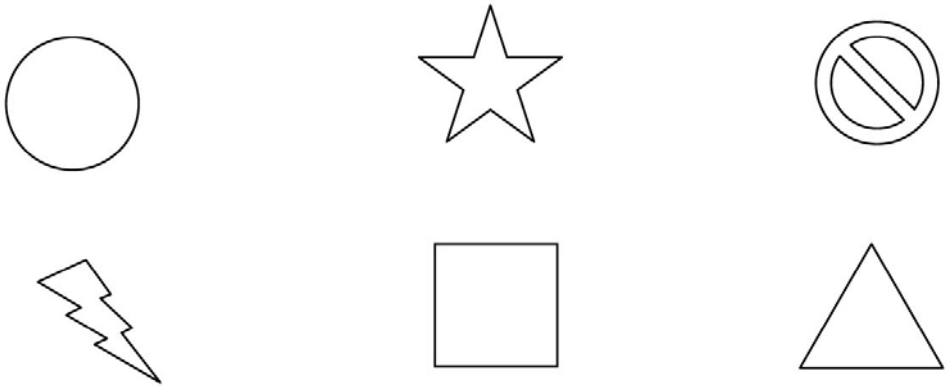
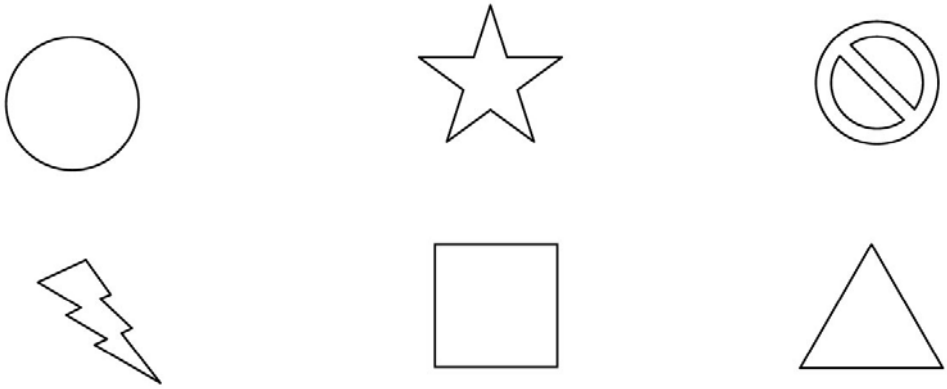
Activity Sheet 4b: **Sixty second challenge**







Activity Sheet 4c (i): **Shapes, colours and emotions**

Stage of Change	Shape	Colour	Emotion
Stage One Prethinking			
Stage Two Thinking			
Stage Three Deciding			
Stage Four Doing			
Stage Five Maintaining			
Stage Six Relapsing			

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Activity Sheet 4c (ii): **Emotions and Feelings**

Here are some examples of feelings and emotions to help you fill in your table. You may wish to look up any words that you are not sure about in the dictionary

Happy

Despairing

Positive

Not bothered

Not caring

In control

Calm

Indifferent

Panicky

OK

Strong

Fine

Worried

Lost control

Angry

Low

Confused

Confident

Upset

Lost

Fantastic

Good

Anxious

Clear direction

Mad

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